SOUTH INDIAN COLLECTION

NO. 05



PAN-SOUTH INDIAN

Lemon Rice

Tangy Tempered Rice with Peanuts
South India's Favorite Lunchbox Staple

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Lemon Rice

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Lemon Rice

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DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Rice That Travels Best

Lemon rice — known as chitranna in Kannada, elumichai sadam in Tamil, and by various other regional names across South India — belongs to a broader category of tempered rice dishes built specifically for practicality: quick to prepare, delicious at room temperature, and resistant to spoiling in a way that makes it ideal for lunchboxes, train journeys, and temple offerings alike.

The dish's technique is straightforward but precise — cooked rice tossed with fresh lemon juice, turmeric, and a generous tempering of mustard seeds, peanuts, chana dal, and curry leaves — but getting the proportions and rice texture right is what separates a forgettable lemon rice from a genuinely craveable one. Too much lemon overwhelms; too little leaves the dish flat, and rice that's even slightly overcooked turns the whole dish mushy rather than pleasantly fluffy.

Because it travels and keeps so well, lemon rice has become one of South India's most ubiquitous prepared foods, found everywhere from home lunchboxes to temple prasadam counters to roadside stalls — a dish valued as much for its convenience as for its bright, tangy flavor.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

The Rice That Travels Best, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

Known by different regional names across South India — chitranna in Karnataka, elumichai sadam in Tamil Nadu — reflecting its pan-regional popularity. Valued specifically for its practicality: it travels well, stays fresh at room temperature, and doesn't spoil quickly, making it ideal lunchbox and travel food. A common offering as temple prasadam (blessed food) across South Indian temples. One of the most ubiquitous prepared rice dishes in South India, found in home kitchens, roadside stalls, and religious settings alike.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	15m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Wide pan or kadai
- Wooden spoon or flat spatula

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Lemon rice keeps at room temperature for several hours, refrigerated for up to 2 days. It's specifically known for traveling and holding up well, making it one of the best make-ahead dishes for lunchboxes and trips. It doesn't freeze well, given the fresh lemon and delicate rice texture.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dish

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Rice, cooked and cooled	3 cups	500 g cooked	3 katori
Oil	3 tbsp	45 ml	3 chammach
Mustard seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Chana dal	1 tbsp	12 g	1 chammach
Urad dal	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Peanuts, raw	3 tbsp	30 g	3 chammach
Dried red chili	2	2	2
Green chili, slit	2	2	2
Curry leaves	2 sprigs	15–20 leaves	2 sprigs
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Lemon juice	3–4 tbsp	45–60 ml	3–4 chammach
Salt	1 tsp	6 g	to taste
Fresh coriander, chopped, for garnish	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

This dish uses only common pantry ingredients, making it highly accessible worldwide. Any variety of rice works, though a slightly separate, non-sticky grain (like basmati or sona masoori) gives the best texture. Fresh lemon juice is strongly preferred over bottled for the brightest flavor.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Lemon Rice

01 START WITH COOLED RICE

Use rice that's been cooked and cooled completely, ideally a few hours ahead or even the previous day — warm, freshly cooked rice turns mushy and clumpy when mixed with lemon juice.

> **Chef tip.** day-old refrigerated rice, fluffed gently, often gives the best texture for this dish, as it's had time to dry out slightly.

02 TEMPER THE SPICES

Heat oil in a wide pan and add mustard seeds, letting them pop. Add chana dal, urad dal, and peanuts, frying until golden, about 2 minutes.

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STEP BY STEP · STEP-BY-STEP

Making Lemon Rice, continued



03 ADD CHILIES AND CURRY LEAVES

Add the dried red chili, slit green chilies, curry leaves, and asafoetida, letting everything sizzle until fragrant.

04 ADD TURMERIC AND RICE

Add the turmeric powder, stirring briefly, then add the cooled rice, tossing gently to distribute the tempering and turmeric color evenly throughout.

05 ADD LEMON JUICE AND SALT

Remove from heat and stir in the lemon juice and salt, tossing gently to combine without breaking the rice grains.

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Making Lemon Rice, continued

Texture indicator. lemon rice should have distinct, separate grains coated evenly in bright yellow color, not clumped or mushy.

06 GARNISH AND SERVE

Finish with fresh coriander.



MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding lemon juice to hot rice, or mixing too vigorously, both risk turning the dish mushy. Toss gently, and consider letting the rice cool slightly more if it feels too warm when the lemon goes in.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Packed for lunchboxes and travel, valued for staying fresh without refrigeration for several hours.
- Served as temple prasadam across many South Indian temples.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Family Style

- A quick, satisfying meal on its own, or alongside a simple side dish like potato chips or papad.

Modern Pairing

- Works well as a bright, tangy side dish alongside grilled vegetables or proteins for a fusion-style meal.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Using cooled, ideally day-old rice is the single biggest factor in achieving distinct, non-mushy grains.
- Tossing gently rather than stirring vigorously preserves the rice's texture once the lemon juice is added.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- This dish is genuinely better made slightly ahead, giving the flavors time to settle — a rare case where resting improves a rice dish.
- Cook rice specifically for this purpose a day in advance for the most reliable results.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some cooks add a small amount of grated raw mango during mango season for extra tang and complexity, layering it alongside or instead of some of the lemon juice.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

280 kcal	6 g	42 g	10 g	2 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Gluten, Peanuts, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Chitranna	the Karnataka name and style for this dish, sometimes with added coconut.
Mango Lemon Rice	made with a portion of grated raw mango alongside lemon juice.
Peanut-Heavy Lemon Rice	some households add extra peanuts for a heartier, crunchier texture.

Why did my lemon rice turn mushy?

Almost always warm or freshly cooked rice being mixed with lemon juice. Always start with cooled, ideally day-old rice.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I use brown rice?

Yes, though the texture and cooking time will differ — brown rice holds its shape well for this dish once cooked and cooled.

Is lemon rice served hot or cold?

It's traditionally served at room temperature, which is part of why it travels so well — no need to reheat.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Chitranna	the Kannada name for this dish, a Karnataka staple.
Elumichai Sadam	the Tamil name for lemon rice, meaning "lemon rice" directly.
Prasadam	food offered to deities in Hindu temples, then distributed to devotees.
Tadka	a tempering of spices bloomed in hot oil, essential to this dish's flavor.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Lemon Rice

10m	15m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	Easy
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DISH

Rice	500 g cooked
Oil	45 ml
Mustard seeds	4 g
Chana dal	12 g
Urad dal	10 g
Peanuts	30 g
Dried red chili	2
Green chili	2
Curry leaves	15–20 leaves
Asafoetida	pinch
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Lemon juice	45–60 ml
Salt	6 g
Fresh coriander	8 g

METHOD

01 **Start with cooled rice.** Use rice that's been cooked and cooled completely, ideally a few hours ahead or even the previous day — warm, freshly cooked rice turns mushy and clumpy when mixed with lemon juice.

02 **Temper the spices.** Heat oil in a wide pan and add mustard seeds, letting them pop.

03 **Add chilies and curry leaves.** Add the dried red chili, slit green chilies, curry leaves, and asafoetida, letting everything sizzle until fragrant.

04 **Add turmeric and rice.** Add the turmeric powder, stirring briefly, then add the cooled rice, tossing gently to distribute the tempering and turmeric color evenly throughout.

05 **Add lemon juice and salt.** Remove from heat and stir in the lemon juice and salt, tossing gently to combine without breaking the rice grains.

06 **Garnish and serve.** Finish with fresh coriander.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐ Rice	500 g cooked	☐ Oil	45 ml
☐ Mustard seeds	4 g	☐ Chana dal	12 g
☐ Urad dal	10 g	☐ Peanuts	30 g
☐ Dried red chili	2	☐ Green chili	2
☐ Curry leaves	15–20 leaves	☐ Asafoetida	pinch
☐ Turmeric powder	1.5 g	☐ Lemon juice	45–60 ml
☐ Salt	6 g	☐ Fresh coriander	8 g

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